

CONVERSATION CHEAT SHEET

Evoking Change

Ten ways to help someone talk themselves toward change, instead of being talked into it. Keep it beside you in session. You will not use all ten. You will reach for the same three, and that is the point.

The principle

Change you argue for is change you resist.
Change they argue for is change they keep.
So ask, do not tell.

How to use it

Skim the ten prompts. Pick the one that fits the moment. Ask it, then stay quiet for longer than feels comfortable.

01**Listen for change talk**

"I want to", "I could", "I wish".
These are the doors.
Reflect them back.

02**Go slow on solutions**

Your best idea lands worse
than their half-formed one.
Ask for theirs first.

03**Stay warm**

Curiosity, not interrogation.
The tone carries more than
the question does.

THE FIRST TWO

01 Ask for examples

When a change theme shows up, pin it to real life. Specifics beat generalities.

- Can you give me an example of "X"?
- When was the last time "X" happened?

02 Ask for more

When they say something half-open, invite them to unpack it. After "I want to change but don't know where to start", try "What do you think is holding you back?"

- In what ways is "X" affecting "Y"?
- How do you imagine that playing out?
- Tell me more about "X".

PROMPTS 03 TO 06

Widen the picture**03 Ask evocative questions**

Questions that get the client arguing for change in their own words. Grouped by what they surface.

Desire Why do you want to make this change? How would you like things to be different?

Importance On a scale of 1 to 10, how important is this? If nothing changes, what are the long-term consequences?

Possibility How might you go about it? What would you do to make it happen?

Borrowed wisdom If you asked someone who has already done this, what advice would they give you?

04 Look back

Find what life was like before the problem. Often the person remembers they were once different.

- How were things before this became a problem?
- What was better then?
- Was there an event that set this off?

06 Name the extremes

Stretch both ends. How would it feel and look at its worst and at its best?

- What is the worst that could happen if you do not change?
- What is the best that could happen if you do?

05 Look forward

Build a picture of the future where it is already solved.

- If six months from now you had overcome this, what would be different?
- How do you see your future unfolding?
- How does this worry shape your future if you do not overcome it?

COACH'S NOTE

Ask about the past and the future in the same conversation. Looking back reminds them they have changed before. Looking forward gives the change somewhere to land.

PROMPTS 07 TO 10

Numbers, values, and the **advanced** pair**07 Use scale questions**

Numbers make a fuzzy feeling workable, and the follow-up does the real work.

- How important is this to you, 1 to 10?
- Why that number? Why not higher, or lower?
- How confident are you that you can do it, and why?

08 Explore values

Check the goal against what they actually care about. A clash here explains a lot of stuck.

- What do you want from life?
- How does "X" fit with your values?
- How does "X" clash with your values?

09 Come alongside

Take the side of not changing, out loud. People often argue themselves out of it. Use with care and warmth, never sarcasm.

- Perhaps "X" matters so much to you that you do not want to give it up, whatever the cost?
- Maybe you do not really want to give up "X", even knowing the long-term effects?

10 Weigh pros and cons

Let them say the case for staying put, then ask whether it is worth the price.

- Do you see any upside to not changing? What is it?
- Is that worth sacrificing your long-term goals?
- What are the downsides now, and in the years ahead, if you do not change now?

USE "COME ALONGSIDE" WITH CARE

It can feel like a trap if trust is thin. Say it gently, mean it, and be ready for "actually, yes, that is how I feel". That is information too. If someone truly does not want to change, that is their right, and your job shifts from persuading to understanding.

Client

Date

The three prompts I will reach for next time